pursued via the study of medicine, i.e., Ayurveda, which aggregated aspects of botany, zoology and chemistry in the service of a practical end: curing and sustaining the human body. Moreover, most of this philosophy occurred in implicitly atheistic frameworks, in a seemingly competitive and high-pressure environment. According to Xuanzang:

> The day is not sufficient for asking and answering profound questions. From morning till night they engage in discussion; the old and the young mutually help one another. Those who cannot discuss questions out of the Tripitaka [core scriptures] are little esteemed and are obliged to hide themselves for shame. Learned men from different cities, on this account, who desire to acquire quickly a renown in discussion, come here in multitudes to settle their doubts, and then the streams [of their wisdom] spread far and wide.[14]

According to Yijing, the main pillars of *vidya*, or knowledge, that Buddhists at the time had to acquire were: (1) *Sabdavidya*, grammar and lexicography, (2) *Silpasthanavidya*, the arts, (3) *Kikitsavidya*, medicine, (4) *Hetuvidya*, logic, and (5) *Adhyatmavidya*, 'science of the universal soul' or philosophy. Also included were readings in the Vedas and Samkhya. Yijing mentions many important texts and authors in each area, though it is by no means an exhaustive list. Since incoming monks at Nalanda had to be at least twenty years old, they had to have acquired enough foundational knowledge elsewhere.

'The Sutra [of Panini] is the foundation of all grammatical science,' writes Yijing. Sutra means 'short aphorism' and 'signifies that important principles are expounded in abridged form'. Panini, writes Yijing, was a scholar of old and a devotee of Shiva. His sutra 'contains 1,000 slokas' and children begin learning it at age eight. They also study *The Book of Dhatu* and *The Book of Three Khilas*, focused on grammar and language. Next is a commentary on Panini's sutra, *The Vritti-sutra*, and *The Kurmi*, by 'the learned Patanjali'. 'Advanced scholars can learn this in three years,' writes Yijing. Next is *Bharatrihari-sastra*, by Bharatrihari, a famous thinker known for his frequent switches between monastic and worldly life. This work 'contains 25,000 slokas, and fully [discusses] the principles of human life as well as of grammatical science'. Another work by Bharatrihari follows, *The Vakya-discourse*, a treatise on inferential and inductive reasoning. *The Peina* is next, comprising 3000 slokas authored by Bharatrihari and a commentary by Dharmapala. It 'fathoms the deep secrets of heaven and earth, and treats of the philosophy of man'. Monks and